



MICROSOFT 365[®]

Setup Guide

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FOCUS OF THIS GUIDE

WHAT YOU CAN EXPECT FROM THIS GUIDE

Our focus with this Guide is to show you how to use the applications in the Microsoft 365® environment for your GTD® workflow.

This Guide is designed around two key outcomes: improving your personal workflow and improving your team's workflow. While many of the applications in Microsoft 365 can serve both purposes, how you use them will depend on the outcome you are trying to achieve.

If you are new to some of the applications in Microsoft 365, this Guide should be an excellent starting point for you to build a solid GTD foundation for optimizing your productivity using the built-in features. If you already have an established system in some of the apps mentioned, use this Guide as an opportunity to fine-tune or simplify, if you have found you've underused or overbuilt your setup.

We are aware that there are many features and ways to configure your system in all the various apps. This is not a technical guide, nor will it cover all the instructions for how to use every feature in every application we cover. We have specific GTD Guides that focus on specific applications, such as Microsoft Outlook®, Microsoft OneNote®, Microsoft To Do, and Microsoft Teams®, if you want to drill down into more detail. Microsoft also offers excellent support through their website for any technical issues you may encounter. The instructions in this Guide match the latest versions of the applications featured as of March 2022.

This Guide focuses on the methods we have found work well for GTD for a wide range of people. And, given the number of applications you can choose from in Microsoft 365, the opportunities to customize your set up are endless. Whatever configuration you choose for your GTD workflow—for yourself and for your team—be careful not to overcomplicate it to the point where you can only maintain it when you are at your peak of mental clarity. It's too easy to have a complicated system fall apart when you're not at your best.

Your GTD tools should be complex enough to manage your workflow, but simple enough that if you were sick in bed with the flu, you could still easily maintain them.

Finally, don't worry about using every available feature and add-on in the applications you choose. There may be more offered than you will ever need. Focus on what makes a difference for you.

OK...let's get started!

Be careful not to overcomplicate your systems to the point where you can only maintain them when you are at your peak of mental clarity.

UNDERSTANDING THE GTD BEST PRACTICES

AN OVERVIEW OF THE KEY BEST PRACTICES OF THE GTD METHODOLOGY

To get the most out of the applications in Microsoft 365 for your GTD practice, let's review the fundamentals of the Getting Things Done[®] approach, so you understand how the methodology and tools will intersect.

WHAT IS GTD?

GTD is the shorthand brand for “Getting Things Done,” the groundbreaking work-life management system and bestselling book¹ by David Allen, which provides concrete solutions for transforming overwhelm and uncertainty into an integrated system of stress-free productivity.

GTD'S FIVE STEPS OF MASTERING WORKFLOW

- **Capture** Collect what has your attention
- **Clarify** Process what it means
- **Organize** Put it where it belongs
- **Reflect** Review frequently
- **Engage** Simply do

THREE STAGES TO INTEGRATING GTD

1. UNDERSTANDING You understand the distinct differences in the five steps of Mastering Workflow. You understand a project versus a next action. You know how to transform what you've collected by asking the key processing questions, clarifying what something is, and what you want to do about it.

2. IMPLEMENTATION You have installed at least the basic gear to support your GTD practice, including ubiquitous collection tools, functioning reference systems for your non-actionable information, and seamless buckets with “clean edges” for tracking your projects and next actions.

3. BEHAVIOR CHANGE The five steps of Mastering Workflow are second nature to you. You have changed the way you think and work and are achieving stress-free productivity on a regular basis. When you “fall off” you know what to do to get “back on.”

¹*Getting Things Done: The Art of Stress-Free Productivity*; Viking, New York; 2001, 2015 hardback or paperback.

APPLYING GTD TO THE MICROSOFT 365 ENVIRONMENT

AN OVERVIEW OF THE MICROSOFT 365 APPLICATIONS

Here is an overview of the applications most relevant in the Microsoft 365 environment for your personal and team workflow. You'll learn about the purpose of the application, the essential functions, and how it relates in the context of GTD.

WORKFLOW MANAGEMENT



MICROSOFT OUTLOOK

Microsoft Outlook is a long-standing application in the Microsoft suite for calendar, email, contact, and task management.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Create, send, receive, filter, read, and file emails
- Calendar management
- Task management, including recurring tasks, due dates, reminders, and file attachments

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Ability to manage GTD lists
- Enables quick processing and organization of emails into tasks
- Provides an interface between Outlook Tasks and Microsoft To Do

You could easily have a dozen people and meetings that you are tracking this way—your direct reports, your boss, your assistant, your spouse, the weekly staff meeting, the monthly board meeting, etc.



MICROSOFT TO DO

Microsoft To Do is a new application in the Microsoft suite for task management.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Task management, including daily planning, recurring tasks, due dates, reminders, file attachments and list sharing

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Ability to manage GTD lists
- Synchronizes with Outlook tasks, allowing full access to the created tasks from both Outlook and To Do
- Serves as the mobile app to view To Do and Outlook tasks
- Powerful web interface

COLLABORATION



MICROSOFT TEAMS

Microsoft Teams is the team workspace in Microsoft 365, offering numerous collaboration functionalities, a variety of interfaces to other Microsoft 365 applications such as Planner, SharePoint, and OneNote, and allows the integration of external applications (e.g., Trello, Zoom, Asana, etc.). The strategic goal is to establish Microsoft Teams as a central hub for collaboration and development. We expect the user interface and features in Teams to change more often than most Microsoft applications.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Collaborate in team spaces and channels
- Manage shared project support
- Communicate in channels and chats
- Meet through calls and video conferences
- Create personal and team Wikis
- Upload and share files (connection to SharePoint)
- Create visibility for team tasks via integration of Microsoft Planner Boards
- Conducting surveys via integration of Microsoft Forms

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Central place for team collaboration
- Hub for file exchange and storage (although file storage is technically on SharePoint)
- Teams can create, plan, and assign tasks via Microsoft Planner Boards or another integrated task board (e.g., Trello or Asana)

Note: *Microsoft Teams is also an excellent choice for your project support.*



MICROSOFT PLANNER

Microsoft Planner is another powerful app in the Microsoft suite for task management. While it is primarily used as a collaborative task tool, it can be used for your personal workflow as well. The most useful functionality with Planner is the ability to use Planner inside of Microsoft Teams, which then syncs tasks to Outlook on the web and Microsoft To Do.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Creation of task lists or boards to manage personal or team tasks
- Tasks can be expanded with files, comments, checklists
- Tasks can be assigned to one or more team members

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Creates visibility of team tasks in kanban-style boards popular with Agile teams or traditional lists
- Interface between Microsoft Planner and Microsoft To Do where assigned tasks from Planner boards are displayed in a separate list in Microsoft To Do. This allows combining task planning as a team with individual task planning.

Note: *Microsoft Planner can also be used for your personal workflow management.*

PROJECT SUPPORT AND REFERENCE MATERIAL



MICROSOFT ONENOTE

Digital notebook application for storing notes, checklists, project support, and reference material.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Create multiple Notebooks, Sections, and Pages
- Easy access to Notebooks across multiple devices, online or offline
- Integrates various content formats such as text, drawings, handwritten notes, files, emails, hotlinks, images, audio recordings, etc.
- Notebooks can be private or shared with others
- Integrates with Outlook

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Creates a trusted space for personal and shared reference and project support material

Note: *Microsoft OneNote can also be used for your personal workflow management.*

SOCIAL NETWORKS



MICROSOFT YAMMER

Yammer is Microsoft's solution for an internal social network within an organization, which dynamically and asynchronously connects the entire company with each other. It is similar in structure and functionality to the well-known social media platforms such as Facebook, LinkedIn, and Slack.

Although like Microsoft Teams, Yammer is often used for large group communications, whereas Teams is designed for more direct communication, collaboration, and intact work groups.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Internal social network within the company to exchange knowledge, experiences, ideas, feedback, and news
- Posts, including files, images and videos that can be clicked, commented, and shared (as known from other social networks) and mentioning internal experts
- Forming subject-related "community groups", e.g., to discuss specific topics, exchange experiences and share contents
- Subscribe to news feeds and follow people

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Additional input channel for ideas and reference material

FILE STORAGE



MICROSOFT SHAREPOINT

Microsoft SharePoint is an online folder system for file storage and includes robust collaboration features for team workflow.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Supports real-time collaborative editing of documents

- Central storage location for files to enable shared access within the team
- Creates a separate storage area for each team space in Microsoft Team, where shared documents are stored within the team, as well as associated notebooks and documents shared in Microsoft Planner Boards
- Option to create your own website to display news, quick links, and latest information in one interface
- Can be used in addition to personal OneDrive storage

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Storage location for project support and reference material
- Collaborative file system to avoid redundancies, version chaos, and ensure that teams can work together in real-time on files



MICROSOFT ONEDRIVE

Microsoft OneDrive is an online folder system for file storage. While not as robust in features as SharePoint, it is still an excellent option for managing reference information.

ESSENTIAL FUNCTIONS

- Backup, access and share personal files in a central location
- Offline access to files
- Storage location for personal files and notebooks
- Can be linked to OneNote

HOW IT RELATES IN THE CONTEXT OF GTD

- Ideal for storing personal reference and project support material

OTHER APPS

The applications we have featured are by no means your only options. We have focused on the most common ones for personal and team productivity and workflow. However, you and your team may find others work just as well, such as Flow, Groups, Delve, Project, Slack, Jira, Wrike, and more. The opportunities to customize your setup are endless. Whatever tools you choose, for your GTD workflow—for yourself and for your team—be careful not to overcomplicate it to the point where you can only maintain it when you are at your peak of mental clarity.

PERSONAL WORKFLOW IN MICROSOFT 365

USING THE APPS IN MICROSOFT 365 FOR YOUR PERSONAL WORKFLOW

In this section you will learn how to approach your personal organization within Microsoft 365. The Five Steps of the GTD workflow serve as the guide for our recommendations.

A FEW NOTES TO START

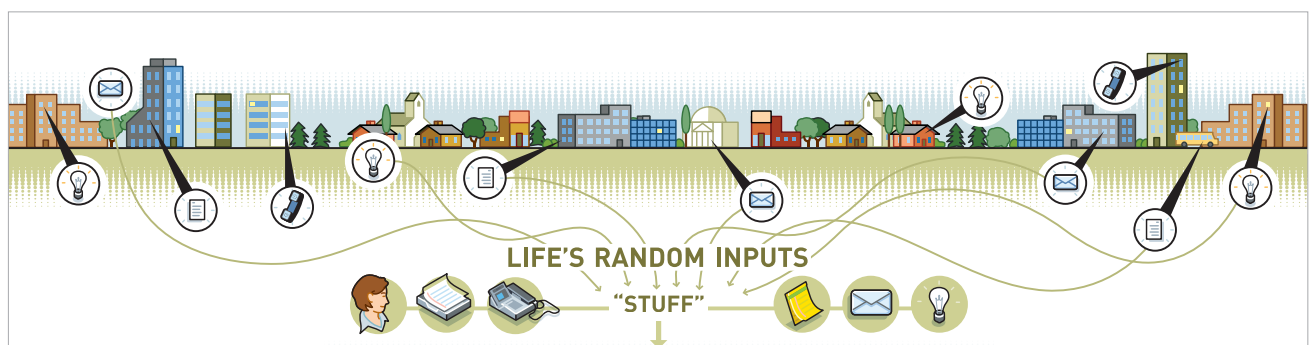
- There are many ways to implement GTD in the Microsoft 365 environment. Which set of tools for you depends both on your personal software preferences and the options available to you.
- The prerequisite for high-functioning team collaboration is that each team member has a trusted system to track their own tasks effectively. Therefore, we start with the personal workflow before going into the team workflow.
- For more specific setup instructions for the Microsoft tools (e.g., Microsoft Outlook, Teams, OneNote), we recommend our GTD Setup Guides for those applications.

STEP 1: CAPTURE

COLLECT WHAT HAS YOUR ATTENTION

Not long ago, email was the primary inbox (capture tool) for most people to receive new digital input that needed to be clarified and organized. Now, with the many apps available to use for collaboration and communication, our potential input has expanded to include new information from messenger apps, project boards, CRMs, and more. We also have analog (hard copy) input we receive through postal mail, meeting notepads, sticky notes, and more.

For stress-free productivity, it is essential to have good strategies and trusted systems for capturing all the input “stuff” that lands in your world, that requires your decision (clarify) and tracking (organize).



We recommend getting the full Workflow Map, with all of the GTD models, which comes as a PDF download. Visit our online store at store.gettingthingsdone.com to learn more.

Take a moment to identify where you regularly receive new input (“stuff”):**Potential input inside of Microsoft 365**

- Information, mentions, and chats in Teams
- Information, mentions, and chats in Yammer
- Assigned tasks in Planner Boards
- Emails in Outlook
- Meeting notes in Word
- Client notes in Dynamics 365
- Shared Notebooks in OneNote
- Assigned tasks in Planner

Potential input outside of Microsoft 365

- Other messengers like Xing, LinkedIn, WhatsApp, iMessage, and SMS
- Other collaboration software like Slack, Trello, Wrike, Confluence, and Jira
- Other software like SAP, Salesforce, and Evernote
- Notes in notetaking apps
- Postal mailbox
- Desk in-tray
- Paper notepads and sticky notes
- Voicemail inboxes
- Personal email inboxes
- Notes applications on your desktop or mobile device
- Photos on your mobile device
- Things that come to your mind

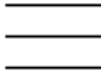
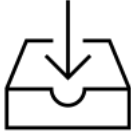
Best practices for Capture

- Capture anything and everything that has your attention in leakproof external “buckets” (your in-trays, email, notepads, voicemail etc.)—get them out of your short-term memory
- Have as few of these collectors as you can, and as many as you need
- Empty them regularly, by processing and organizing

Common challenges with Capture

- Collecting input in too many places and losing track of where to go to clarify and organize
- Reading a new message in Teams without clarifying it at the time (and then message gets lost because it shows as being read)
- Losing track of which input channel someone wanted something from you
- Using captured input as a to do list, without clarifying what it means and what you need to do about it
- Relying on marking new input unread to remind you to get back to it

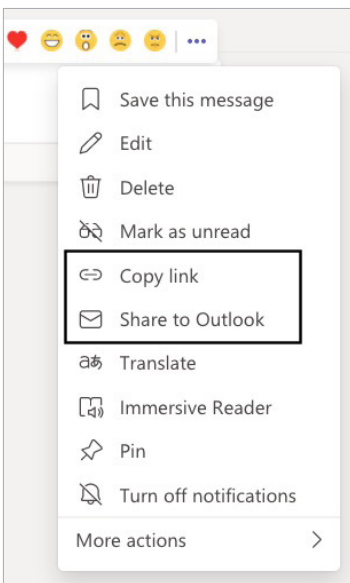
Example of trusted Capture tools

Email inbox in Outlook	Activity Feed in Teams	Electronic inbox list in Outlook Tasks, To Do, or OneNote Notebook	Physical in-tray in your office and “In” folder for travel/commuting
			

EXAMPLES OF USING TRUSTED CAPTURE TOOLS IN YOUR GTD WORKFLOW

Using your email inbox for more than email

For example, if you’re a Teams user and get a message in a Chat that requires action, click on the ellipsis to the right of the message and choose Copy link or Share to Outlook to send it to your trusted email inbox in Outlook to clarify and organize later:



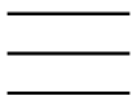
Using your physical in-tray in your office and “In” folder for travel/commuting

Create a trusted in-tray for gathering physical notes, hard copy mail, sticky notes, etc. For example, if you like to take handwritten meeting notes, rather than leaving the notes in your notepad with the nagging sense there may be action buried in those notes, instead, after the meeting, tear out those notes and put them into your in-tray on your desk (or folder for on the go) to clarify and organize later.



Using an electronic list for consolidating input to be clarified

Designate one list in your list manager for new, unclarified input. For example, in Outlook Tasks or To Do, use the default list called “Tasks” not as a list for your GTD next actions, but as an inbox for clearing your mind and capturing input from any other channel that you want to clarify and organize later.



Having a trusted Capture system means you regularly ask yourself:

- Do I have action with this input I just received?
- Is the place I received this input a trusted capture tool I will get back to, to process and organize the item? Or do I need to funnel this to one of my trusted capture tools?

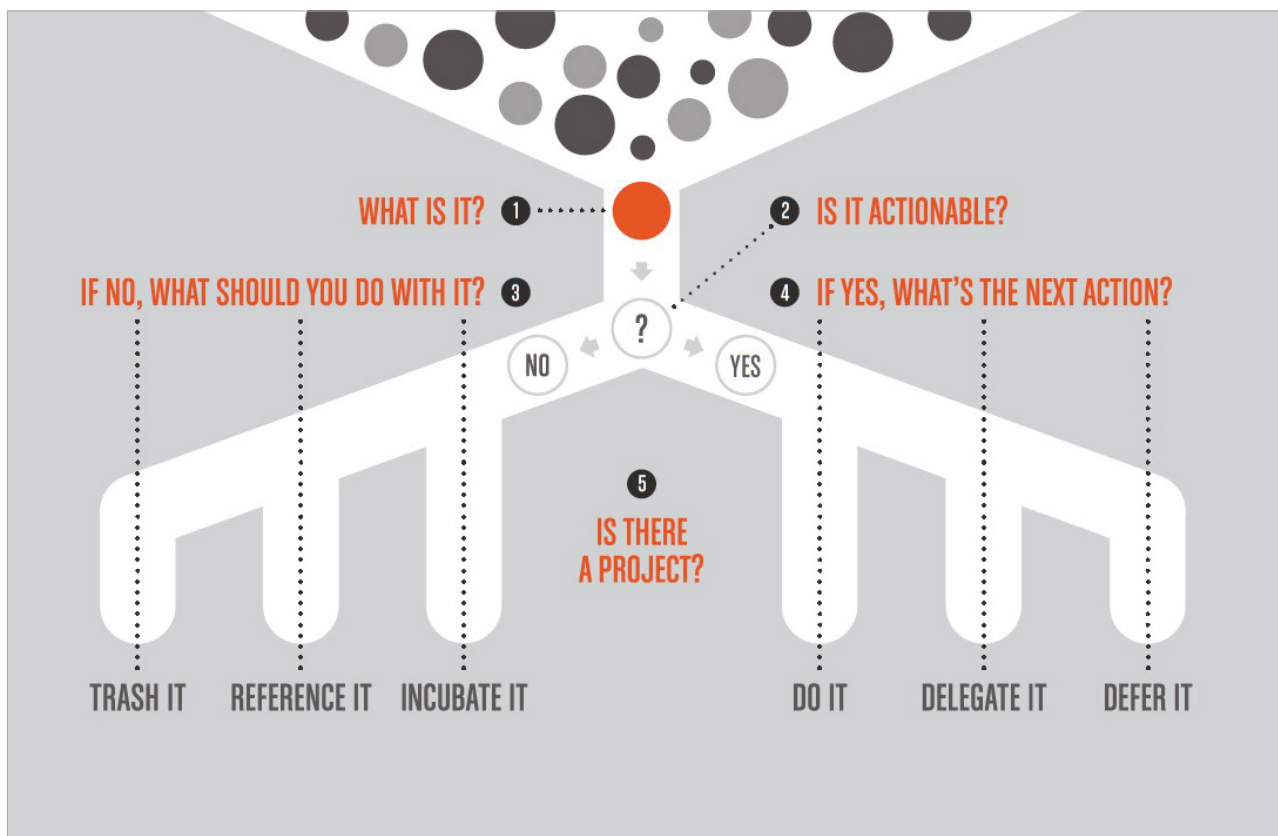
STEP 2: CLARIFY

PROCESS WHAT IT MEANS

Clarify means regularly going through your capture tools to process the items you have collected (decide what each thing means, specifically).

CLARIFYING IN 5 QUESTIONS:

1. **What is it?**
2. **Is it actionable?**
3. **If no, what should you do with it?**
 - Trash it (delete or archive)
 - Reference it (file it)
 - Incubate it (for possible later action)
4. **If yes, what's the next action?**
 - Do it (if less than two minutes)
 - Delegate it (track on Waiting For list)
 - Defer it (put it on a Next Actions list)
5. **Is there a project?** (If one action will not close the loop, then identify the commitment as a “project” and put it on a Projects list.)



Remember, clarifying includes all the capture tools where you receive input that needs your decision, such as meeting notes captured in OneNote, Outlook email, activity feed, chat messages, and @mentions in Teams, chats in Yammer, assigned tasks in Planner, etc.

STEP 3: ORGANIZE

PUT IT WHERE IT BELONGS

BEST PRACTICES FOR ORGANIZE

Group the results of processing your input into appropriately retrievable and reviewable categories. Organize include actionable and non-actionable items.

The four key action categories are:

- Projects (projects you have a commitment to finish within the next 12–18 months, captured with a verb defining your desired outcome)
- Calendar (actions that must occur on a specific day or time)
- Next Actions (actions to be done as soon as possible, add sub-categories if it makes them easier to use)
- Waiting For (projects and actions others are supposed to be doing, which you care about)

COMMON SUB-CATEGORIES OF NEXT ACTIONS LISTS:

Agendas	This list tracks the topics and agenda items for people you interact with regularly. Agendas are for standing items to discuss or bring to a meeting. They are not where you would go to be reminded of a next action you have related to that person.
Anywhere	An action that can be accomplished, without any restriction about where it's done, would go on this list.
Calls	Place reminders of calls you need to make on this list if they can be made from any phone. If a call requires a specific location instead (like home or office), we recommend putting the action in one of those lists instead.
Computer	If the action requires a computer (e.g., emails to send, documents to edit or draft, spreadsheets to develop, websites to visit, data to review, etc.), add it to this list. Even if you only have a computer in the office, it's still convenient to have this list separate from your Office list of things to do, because you wouldn't need to look at this list when you are looking for non-computer things to do. Many people these days also like to have a separate Computer list just for email next actions, given their volume.
Errands	This holds reminders of things that you need to do when you are "out and about."
Home	This list is for next actions that must be done in your home environment.
Office	This list is for next actions that must be done in your office environment.

USING A WAITING FOR LIST

The Waiting For list keeps track of all the actions, projects, and deliverables that you want to happen, but which are someone else's responsibility. It could be something you've ordered that hasn't come yet, something you've handed off to your assistant for which you're waiting on a response or something your boss is supposed to be finding out before you can move forward on a key project. Typically, we suggest adding the date you started waiting in the description of the item. This can be helpful when deciding when it's time to follow up again if they have not responded. The Waiting For list should be reviewed as necessary (at least once a week in the GTD Weekly Review), triggering appropriate actions on your part to follow up, light a fire, or just check the status.

The lists we have suggested should serve as a starting point. You may need more of these or fewer. For example, some people find they want to break out Computer into more specific lists, such as personal vs. professional, or a list just for email-related next actions. Executive support staff can often use a context called Meetings to Schedule. Some managers find a Projects-Delegated list useful as a high-level Waiting For list. Or, you may find you don't want to use as many contexts, and a simple list called Next Actions, or Next Actions-Work and Next Actions-Personal would suffice for your action lists.

Be willing to experiment to find the set of action lists that will work best for you.

Other lists and systems to consider:

- Add lists of longer horizon goals and values that influence you.
- Add checklists that may be useful as needed (job description, event trigger lists, org charts, etc.).
- Maintain a general reference filing system for information and materials that have no action, but which need to be retrievable.
- Maintain an incubate system for triggers of possible actions at later dates (Someday/Maybe lists, calendar, tickler).
- Maintain support information files for projects as needed (can be kept in reference system or in pending area).

Organizing personal workflow in Microsoft 365

For your actionable items, such as Projects, Next Actions, and Waiting For lists, you have several options:

- Outlook Tasks
- Microsoft To Do
- Microsoft OneNote
- Microsoft Planner

Outlook Tasks and Microsoft To Do are excellent options for organizing your personal workflow in the 365 environment. Both applications are built as traditional list managers, giving you an easy way to create the recommended GTD lists. Although less common for personal tasks and more often used for assigned team tasks, Microsoft Planner can also be used effectively for GTD list management. We will cover the keys to using each of these tools as your integrated life management system and you can decide which one works best for you.

Some things to note:

- The tasks app in Windows is called Outlook Tasks.
- The tasks app in Outlook on the web is Microsoft To Do.
- The tasks app in Mac redirects to Microsoft To Do on the web.
- Microsoft To Do is used on the web, your desktop, or your mobile device and is also the mobile application for Outlook Tasks.
- You can use Outlook Tasks or Microsoft To Do and your data should sync seamlessly across all platforms. Which one you choose will be personal preference and any requirements established by your IT department.
- Microsoft Planner tasks will appear in the “Assigned to me” view in To Do if you have been assigned to the task.

Please see our [GTD Setup Guides](#) for best practices and detailed instructions on setting up Outlook for Windows, Outlook for Mac, Microsoft To Do or Microsoft OneNote for your personal system. We do not offer a Setup Guide for Microsoft Planner at this time.

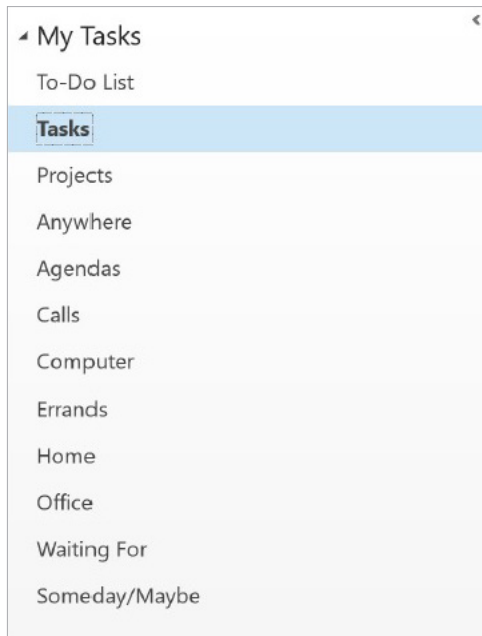
OUTLOOK TASKS FOR WINDOWS

Outlook for Windows is one of the longest standing standard applications and is one of the most widely used email clients. The Tasks application is a good candidate for your GTD lists for its seamless integration with your

Outlook Mail and Calendar. Outlook Tasks are synced to the Microsoft To Do app on your mobile device.

In Outlook Tasks, we recommend your GTD lists be created as Task folders. Each list uses a unique folder, which also supports syncing these lists to the Microsoft To Do mobile app.

Example of lists view:

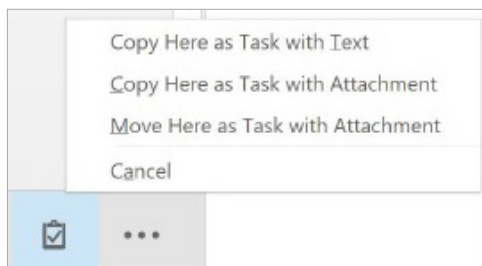


Example of computer list:



Integrating Email

Outlook Tasks for Windows also integrates seamlessly with the Mail application in Outlook. To turn an email into a Task, right-click on the email and drag it over the Tasks icon in the bottom-left navigation bar. Let go of your mouse and choose Copy or Move Here as Task with Attachment. The email will appear in the notes field as a file attachment. Change the subject line to capture your next action, use the keyboard shortcut Ctrl + Shift + V to move the email to the correct Tasks list. Press OK to save the new Task.



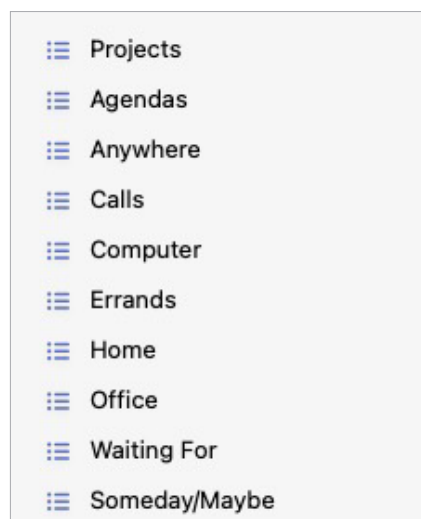
MICROSOFT TO DO AND OUTLOOK TASKS FOR MAC

Microsoft To Do is a relatively new app in the 365 family and is an excellent choice for your GTD lists. Many people prefer the more modern interface of To Do over Outlook Tasks. It is also very intuitive and user friendly. To Do can be accessed on the web, through a desktop app, or mobile app.

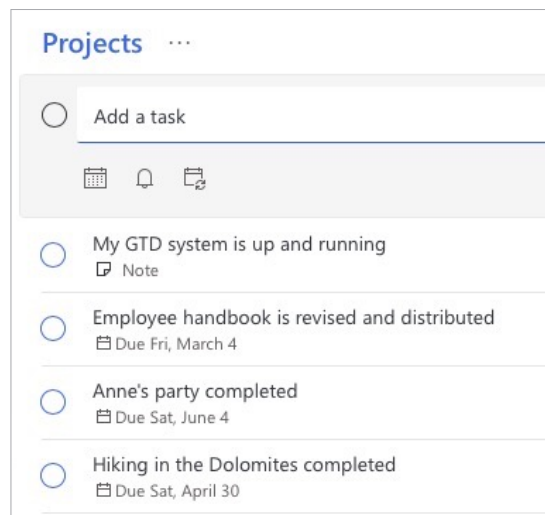
If you use the latest versions of Outlook for Mac on your desktop, your Tasks do not live within the desktop application but are redirected to Microsoft To Do.

We recommend your GTD lists be created as new lists in To Do.

Example of lists view:



Example of projects list:



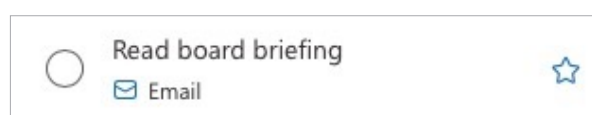
Integrating Email

Turning emails into new tasks is possible with To Do, depending on the Mail application you are using. The most straightforward and seamless integration with Mail and To Do will be if you are using Outlook on the web. This will allow you to drag an email to the right margin of Mail on the web and create a new Task in To Do.

To integrate your Outlook Calendar and To Do with Outlook email, click on the My Day icon in your inbox.

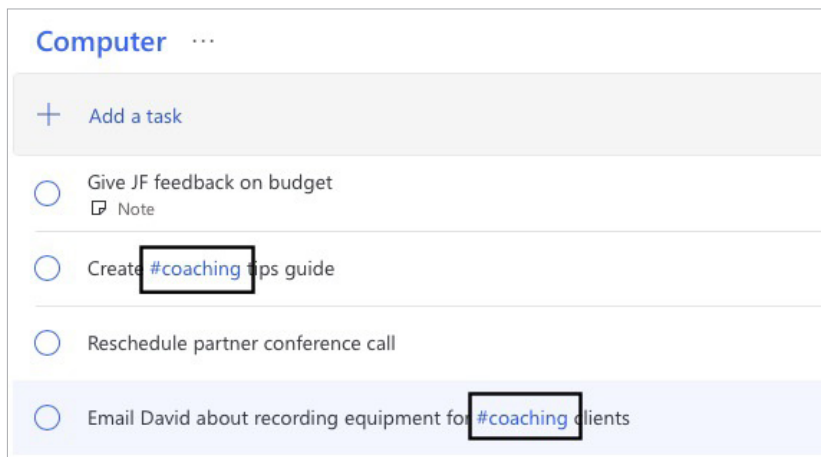


Once clicked, a snip of your Calendar and To Do lists will appear in the right margin. To create a new Event (Calendar entry) or task (To Do item), click and drag the email over to the My Day view in the right margin. Drop the email over the box for the type of entry you'd like to create. Right-click to change any properties of the task, including assigning it to the correct list. An email icon appears in the task, allowing you to click on the Cloud-stored email to easily get back to it.



Tagging

To Do also offers the additional functionality of tagging, which is not possible in Outlook for Windows. Tagging gives you the ability to easily link and view related items, such as all items related to a particular topic or Area of Focus.

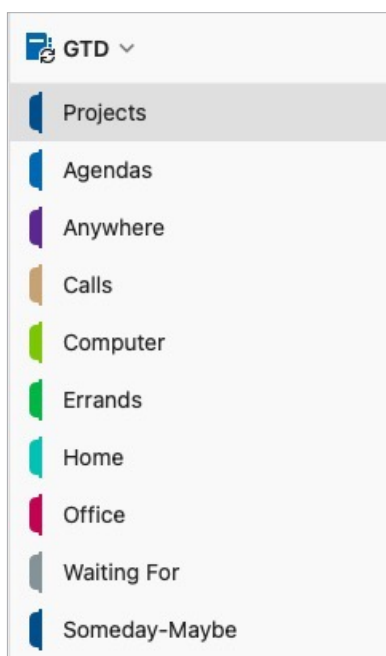


ONENOTE FOR LIST MANAGEMENT

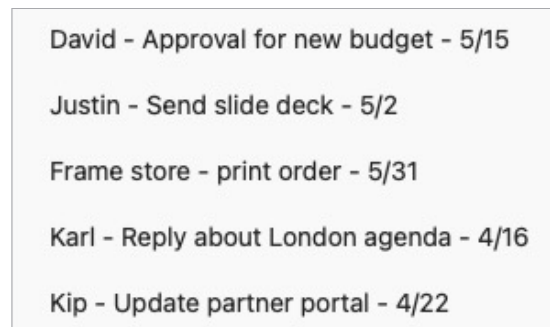
Although more commonly used to store project and reference information, Microsoft OneNote can also be used as a personal list manager. Some people like the large canvas OneNote provides for capturing additional information about their projects and next actions.

We recommend you create a Notebook called GTD, and then your GTD lists are created as Sections, with list items as Pages.

Example of lists view:

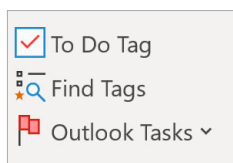


Example of Waiting For list:



The downside of OneNote is that traditional list management features, like adding due dates, won't be an option except manually in the subject line of the item.

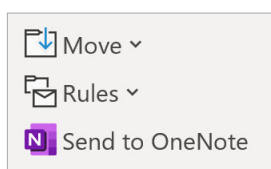
If you are a Windows user, you can integrate OneNote for Windows with Outlook Tasks for Windows, by linking some of your Pages (list entries) in OneNote to your Task lists in Outlook. While it would be overkill to link all your list items, this feature could be useful for linking your projects and related project support in OneNote to the related project next actions stored in Outlook. In other words, OneNote could store your project support (e.g., plans, notes, future actions) in Notebooks and/or Pages and Outlook could track your tactical next actions on your Task lists. You will see an option to create an Outlook Task in your OneNote for Windows ribbon.



Unfortunately, this Tasks integration is not an option on the web or Mac.

Integrating Email

Another useful feature in OneNote is the ability to email information into your OneNote Notebooks. In Outlook for Mac or Windows, you will find a Send to OneNote option in the ribbon.



Unfortunately, this Send to OneNote feature is not an option in Outlook on the web.

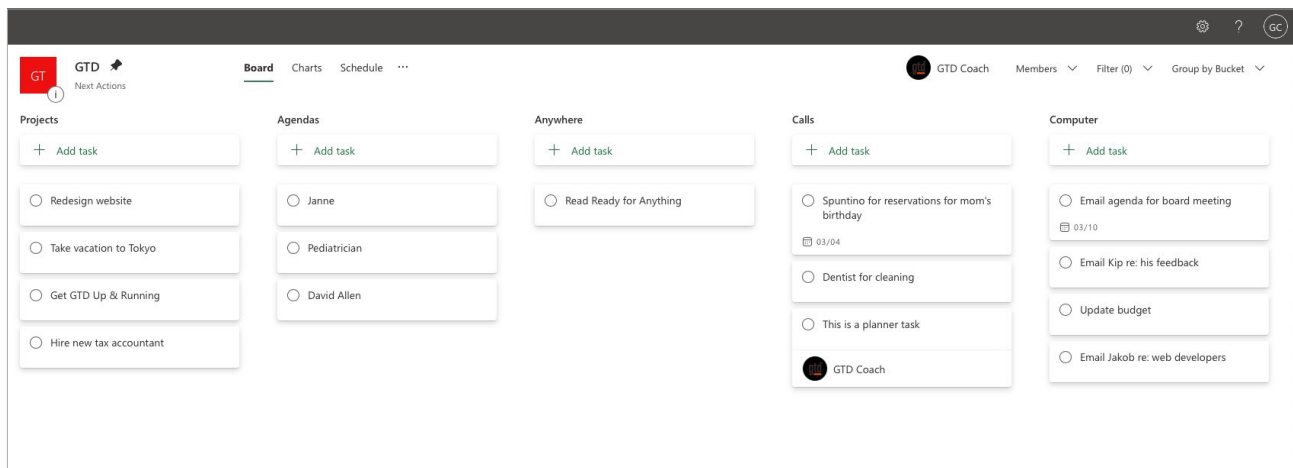
Tagging

OneNote also offers the functionality of tagging, which gives you the ability to easily link and view related items, such as all items related to a particular topic or Area of Focus. The Tag feature is configured differently across each version of Outlook, but the functionality is essentially the same. Add a tag to the subject or body of the item and then search (Find Tag on Windows) to view all items associated with that tag.

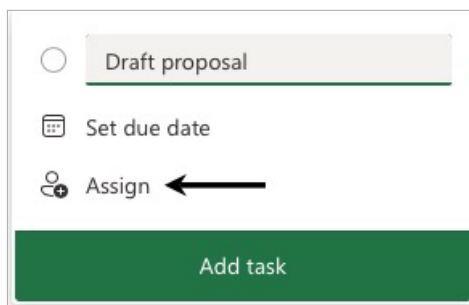
PLANNER FOR TASKS

Although less common for personal list management, it is possible to use Planner as a list option as well. Planner may be less intuitive, in our experience, than using Outlook Tasks or To Do. But if you like the Kanban “board” concept and want one central application for both personal and team actions, it’s a possibility.

We recommend you create a Plan called GTD and then create your individual GTD lists as new Buckets.



If you want your Planner tasks to also appear in Microsoft To Do or in Outlook Tasks for Windows, you will need to assign yourself to the task for the tasks to appear under the “Assigned to me” view in those apps.

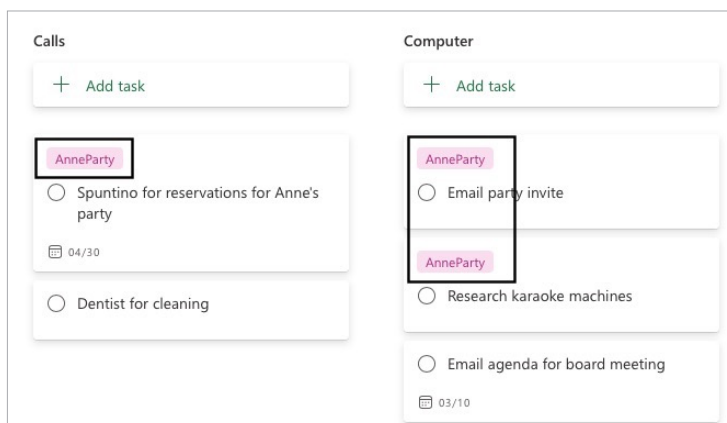


Integrating Email

Integrating email with Planner is not possible as a direct connection like it is within Outlook, as it’s built as more of an independent application (although Planner tasks are synced to the Assigned to me view). You will need to capture the task manually from emails. By no means is this a deal breaker for using Planner, but useful to know if that’s an important feature for you.

Using Labels

The Planner equivalent of tags is labels, to pull related information together easily.



We believe the power of Planner is really when teams use it for visibility on shared projects. This is especially popular now in Microsoft Teams, inside team channels. We'll dive into that more in the Team Workflow section.

We hope this has been a useful overview of your personal workflow management choices in the 365 environment. Choose the one you are most drawn to for its design, features, and ease of use.

ORGANIZING REFERENCE

There are two ways to think of your non-actionable reference information:

Project Support: Information and files containing additional data about a project, such as project plans, project meeting notes, budget tables, etc.

General Reference: Information you want to hold on to but is not related to a current project.

For both types of material, you need routines and best practices to store them effectively for easy access and retrieval.

Which tools you use for your reference (and you will likely use a combination of applications) will depend on storage and retention guidelines from your IT department, who else needs to access the information, and your personal preferences.

Personal Storage Options (Others do not need access)	Shared Storage Options (Others may need access)
Outlook email folders Notes field within Outlook Tasks Outlook Notes	Microsoft Team Channels OneDrive Folders SharePoint Folders OneNote Notebooks Yammer Posts

For more information about setting up and managing your reference in Outlook, OneNote, or Teams, please refer to our Setup Guides.

STEP 4: REFLECT

REVIEW FREQUENTLY

Any tools you use will take effort to keep clean and current, so that you can trust your action choices. Here are the recommended best practices for reflecting on your system:

- On a daily basis, review your calendar and Next Actions lists based on where you are and what you are able to accomplish in that context.
- Conduct a customized weekly review to get clear, get current, and get creative (see GTD Weekly Review[®] below).
- Review the longer-horizon lists of goals, values, and visions as often as required to keep your Projects list complete and current.

THE GTD WEEKLY REVIEW[®] CHECKLIST

The GTD Weekly Review² is what ties this whole thing together, ensuring that you have actions for all the active parts of your projects on a consistent basis, so you can trust that what you are choosing from your Next Actions lists is current. The GTD Weekly Review steps include:

GET CLEAR

Capture Loose Papers and Materials

Gather all accumulated business cards, receipts, and miscellaneous paper-based materials into your in-tray.

Get “IN” to Zero

Clarify completely all outstanding paper materials, journal and meeting notes, voicemails, dictation, and emails.

Empty Your Head

Put in writing and clarify any uncaptured new projects, action items, waiting for's, someday/maybe's, etc.

GET CURRENT

Review Next Actions Lists

Mark off completed actions. Review for reminders of further action steps to record.

Review Previous Calendar Data

Review past calendar in detail for remaining action items, reference data, etc., and transfer into the active system.

Review Upcoming Calendar

Review upcoming calendar events—long and short term. Capture actions triggered.

Review Waiting For List

Record appropriate actions for any needed follow-up. Check off received ones.

Review Project (and Larger Outcome) Lists

Evaluate status of projects, goals, and outcomes, one by one, ensuring at least one current action item on each. Browse through project plans, support material, and any other work-in-progress material to trigger new actions, completions, waiting for's, etc.

² See the *Getting Things Done* book or our GTD Methodology Guides for a GTD Weekly Review checklist.

Review Any Relevant Checklists

Use as a trigger for any new actions.

GET CREATIVE

Review Someday/Maybe List

Review for any projects which may now have become active, and transfer to “Projects”. Delete items no longer of interest.

Be Creative & Courageous

Any new, wonderful, hare-brained, creative, thought-provoking, risk-taking ideas to add into your system???

STEP 5: ENGAGE

SIMPLY DO

Once you have captured, clarified, organized, and reflected on your commitments, now it's time to do.

CRITERIA FOR CHOOSING

There are four criteria for choosing what to do:



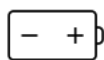
Context: What can I do where I am and what tools I have at hand?

Most next actions require a specific location (such as at home or at your office) or having a specific tool at hand (a phone, computer, or Wi-Fi). Context is the first criteria that limits your choices about what you can do in that moment.



Time: How much time do I have?

Knowing how much time you have available will influence your choices. You will make very different choices knowing you have 20 minutes before you need to go into your next meeting versus several hours where you could dive into a more complex next action.



Resources: How much energy do I have?

You no doubt have swings in your energy throughout the day that will influence what you choose to do. If you're at peak mental clarity and energy, you may choose something that requires a high-level of concentration. If your energy is lowest at the end of the day or week, you might choose an entirely different task that you can handle easily.

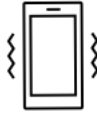


Priority: What will benefit me the most?

Revisit and recalibrate your commitments at appropriate intervals for the various horizons of life and work so when you ask, “What is the value to me of doing X instead of doing Y?” you trust your decision.

THREE-FOLD NATURE OF WORK

Where will you choose from? You have a choice of doing three very different things when you work—predefined work, unplanned work, and defining your work.

		
Predefined Work Working off your inventory of actions and projects—work that you have already determined needs doing.	Unplanned Work Doing the work as it shows up to be done. You are defining your work rapidly in this case and choosing to do the new stuff instead of working off your existing inventory.	Defining Work This is processing and emptying your in-tray, your email, your meeting notes, etc., assessing the new inputs and making decisions about what needs to be done about them.

We hope this has been a useful overview for you on the best practices for your personal workflow. Having this foundation will be integral to productive team workflow, which we will dive into next.

TEAM WORKFLOW IN MICROSOFT 365

Microsoft 365 offers two applications for dynamic and productive collaboration: Planner and Teams. They can be used as stand-alone applications or Planner can be integrated into Teams to capture and track team projects next actions.

MICROSOFT PLANNER



USING MICROSOFT PLANNER FOR TEAM WORKFLOW

Planner is an excellent option for tracking and bringing visibility to actions being taken across the organization or within an intact team. It's built in the Kanban board style of list management, with Buckets representing lists and tasks within each Bucket representing assigned actions.

Advantages of Planner	Key Features of Planner
• Easy and intuitive user experience • Assign tasks to people added to a Plan • Efficient collaboration through transparency about task assignment and statuses • Visual display of tasks, statistics, etc. • Reduces the need for coordination and agreement via email or in meetings • Shared files are stored and saved in SharePoint	• Create task boards for management and assignment of tasks • Different grouping options of tasks (buckets, assigned to, status, due date, names, and priority) • Status diagrams and statistics • Project calendar: Displays scheduled tasks in a calendar that can be imported into Outlook • File exchange (using SharePoint) • Planner Hub: personal overview of all assigned tasks from all Planner boards within the same Microsoft 365 account • Integrate OneNote notebooks into the Planner board



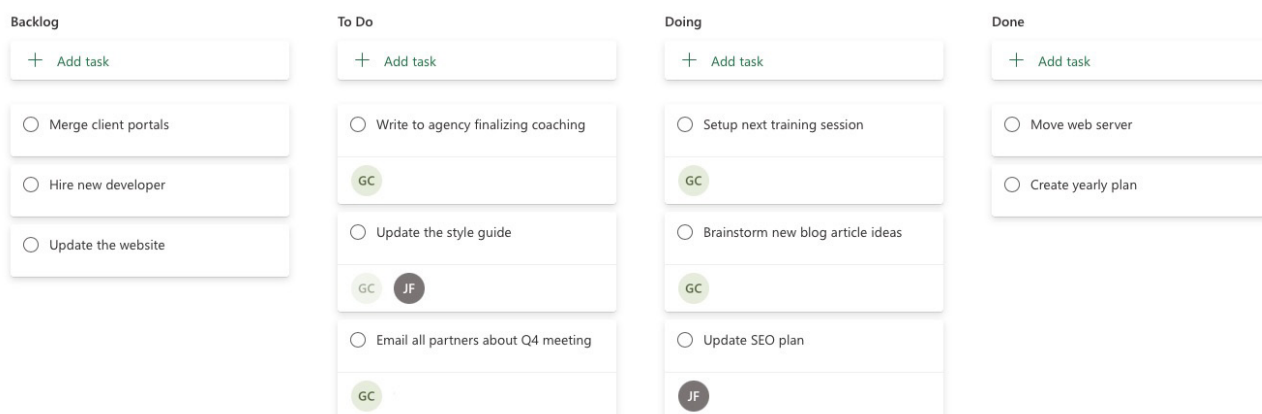
Mobile Applications and Web Client

Planner is available in a web client and as a mobile solution (smartphone, tablet). A desktop app for Windows and Mac is currently not available. However, the Teams desktop application gives you full access to all Planner boards created within Microsoft Teams and to the Planner Hub.

INTEGRATING KANBAN STYLE BOARDS

If you are using Planner for your personal workflow management, as we described earlier in the Guide, we recommend organizing your Planner Buckets by context. For team workflow, many teams use the Kanban principle, which can be used instead, if you prefer. Kanban suggests the following Buckets:

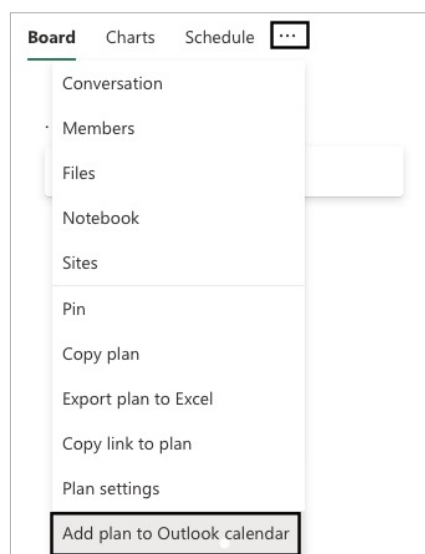
- **Backlog:** All tasks to be completed in the project or team
- **To Do:** Tasks to do next (these should be clearly defined and assigned and should be of a “feasible” size)
- **Doing:** Tasks that are currently in progress
- **Done:** Tasks that have been completed (some teams agree to only mark tasks together as done)



Some teams add Waiting For and Someday/Maybe Buckets to their team Board as well. Whatever setup you choose, we recommend having as many Buckets as you need, but as few as you can get by with.

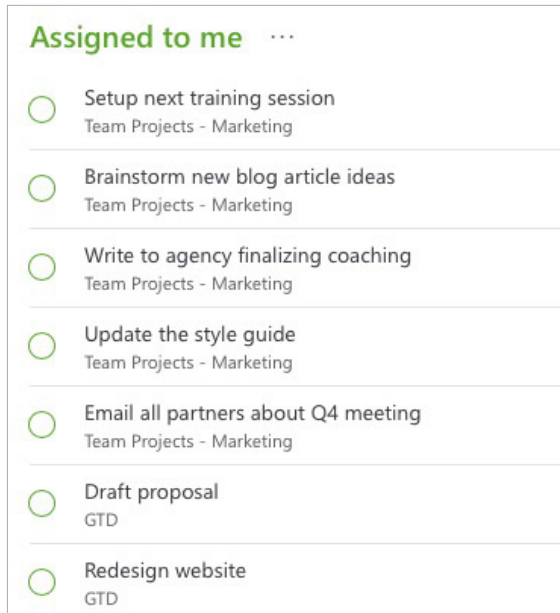
INTEGRATING PLANNER TASKS WITH YOUR OUTLOOK CALENDAR

Integrate any Planner Plan into your Outlook calendar to have an overview of due dates. To do this, click the ellipsis to the top of the Planner Board and choose Add plan to Outlook calendar, and follow the prompts.

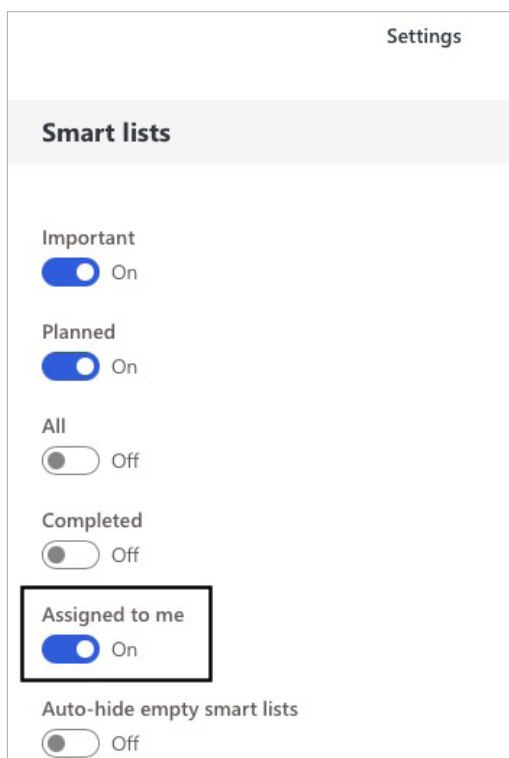


INTEGRATING PLANNER AND MICROSOFT TO DO

If you use Microsoft To Do, Planner tasks assigned to you will automatically appear in the Assigned to me view in your personal To Do account. Changes made in either location will sync automatically.



If you're not seeing the Assigned to me view in To Do, be sure it's toggled on under To Do Settings > Smart Lists.



INTEGRATING YOUR PERSONAL WORKFLOW WITH YOUR TEAM WORKFLOW

If you are being assigned actions in Planner through your Team Boards, it's also important to have a clear process for integrating those actions into your personal workflow. Here are two options for how you could manage that.

Option One:

Copy and paste your Planner tasks into your lists in Outlook. With this option, it takes more effort, but means you have all your projects and actions coordinated in one set of GTD lists, sorted by the categories we recommend (Projects, Computer, Waiting For, etc.). It also gives you the opportunity to rewrite the item in a way that defines your next action.

Option Two:

View your Planner Tasks only under Assigned to me view in Outlook. With this option, it means you are looking at both your GTD lists and your Planner/Assigned to me list as separate lists. Also, your Planner tasks will not be sorted by category or context. This option is risky because assigned tasks, in our experience, rarely describe your discreet next action. Instead, they often only describe an area or topic that needs to get handled (such as "Fix website error") versus the next action (such as "Setup meeting with Carla re: website error message").

RECOMMENDED GOVERNANCE AND GUIDELINES FOR USING PLANNER

One of the challenges Planner users face has been a lack of clear guidelines about how the Planner application is used. In many apps, how you choose to use it is up to you and your personal preference (like Outlook Tasks or using Planner for your personal workflow). Using Planner collaboratively, however, is a team effort. As your use of Planner grows, it will be important to get clear on some guidelines and governance for how to use it productively. Here are some talking points to bring up with your team:

1. Are we using Microsoft Planner to assign tasks or @mention? And is everyone clear how they will get notified when they are assigned tasks?
2. Who can create new Planner Plans and Boards?
3. Who will own and maintain created Boards?
4. What will be the naming convention for creating Plans and Boards?
5. Which tasks should be captured in a Board versus in personal systems and in how much detail?
6. Will the Comments feature be used?
7. How and who will be marking tasks as complete? The individual assigned, the Board owner, or anyone on the team?
8. What is the protocol for assigning due dates to assigned tasks?
9. How will labels be used? (e.g., by project, area of focus, priority, etc.)
10. Where will our files be managed? In SharePoint, OneDrive, or other location?
11. What will be our quality check system to see if how we're working is working?

MICROSOFT TEAMS



USING MICROSOFT TEAMS FOR TEAM WORKFLOW

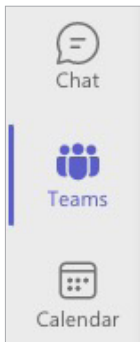
Teams is a communication and collaboration tool. Most people use Teams with their intact team or organization, although it is possible to use Teams individually for your personal workflow. In either case, you will need the business/pro version of Microsoft 365 to have full access to the features Teams offers. If you are on the personal/home version of Microsoft 365, you will typically not have access to the team collaboration functionality in shared spaces or integration of other applications—you will only have access to meetings, chat, and Outlook calendar sync.

Teams is a unique tool in that it's both a portal and destination. As a portal, it serves as a dashboard to other applications you use in your day-to-day workflow, such as Outlook, OneNote, and SharePoint. As a destination, it stores information for you in team spaces, for your own use or to collaborate with others.

Teams can't serve (yet) as your primary system for email, calendar, and lists. We are assuming you are still managing those in Outlook for Windows, Mac, or Web, or using another tool. Teams syncs with those apps, but does not fully host those within Teams, such that you don't need those other apps. At some point that might change, as Teams evolves, but at this point you will still be doing some activities like email in another application.

Advantages of Teams	Key Features of Teams
• Improves asynchronous collaboration • Reduces complexity by combining different applications under one roof • Replaces email volume by using chat messages and conversation threads instead • Saves and stores shared files in SharePoint • Easy access to reference information	• Shared spaces for managing projects • Shared file storage via SharePoint and OneDrive which enables version control and coauthoring in the same document • View Outlook Calendar • View shared OneNote Notebooks • Wiki app to capture notes and ideas • Task management through integration of Planner Boards • Possibility to integrate numerous other Microsoft 365 and third-party provider applications • Activity feed to keep track of various team activities and personal notifications • Surveys, questionnaires, and instant polls via integration of Microsoft Forms • Audio team meetings and video conferencing (Microsoft Teams is the successor of Skype for Business) • Group and 1:1 chats • Add external guests

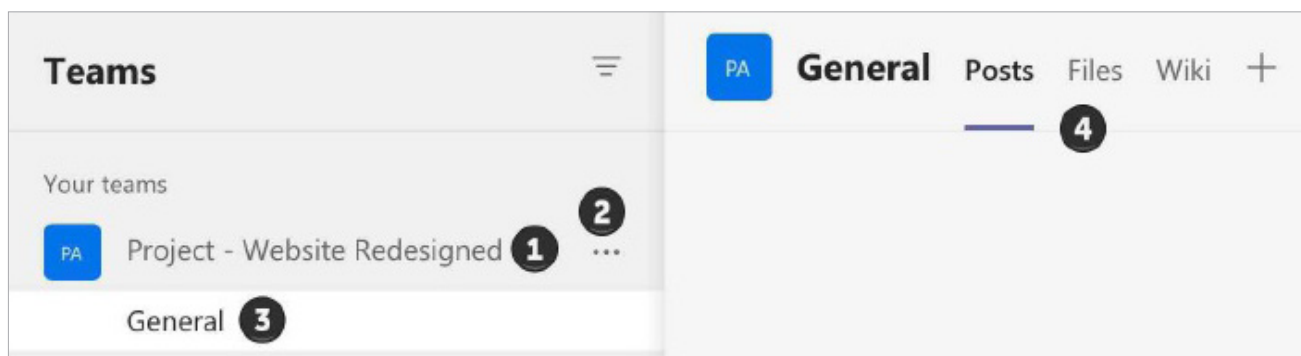
Collaborating on projects in Teams is one of the most powerful aspects of the app. This is done through the teams in Microsoft Teams (yes, a mouthful!). You'll see your teams spaces (sometimes called teams rooms in Microsoft support) as an option in the left navigation.



Think of these as shared spaces to capture reference, have discussions, and capture team tasks on topics and projects. In this Guide, we'll demonstrate how to use them for shared projects.

Each team has four key areas:

1. **Team name** – The overall space where you will be collaborating.
2. **Team settings** – Settings for your team, including adding members and seeing analytics.
3. **Channels** – Rooms within your team for managing information. The default will always be General, which cannot be deleted or renamed. You can add additional Channels.
4. **Tabs** – Think of these as different types of workflows you will be doing, such as discussions, managing files, capturing notes, and integrating other applications.

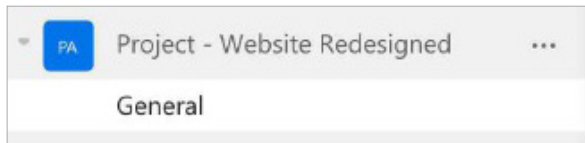


The default Tabs are Posts, Files, and Wiki, and +.

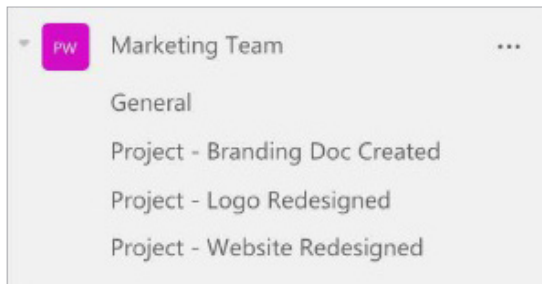
- **Posts** – The feed for activity and conversations within a Channel from all members. This Tab cannot be deleted or renamed.
- **Files** – File storage within a Channel. Any team member can upload files here. This Tab cannot be deleted or renamed. All files across all your Channels can be found in the left navigation under the Files icon.
- **Wiki** – A simple text capture app for storing ideas, notes, and project plans. Any team member can add to or edit Wiki content. This Tab can be deleted or renamed.
- **+** – Picker for choosing additional Tabs to add, such as more Wikis, Microsoft Planner Boards (through the app called Tasks by Planner and To Do), or other applications. Any team member can add new Tabs.

Two options for managing projects in Teams:

1. Create a separate team for each major project



2. Create a team for all projects by Areas of focus and accountability³ and create separate Channels for each project



USING MICROSOFT PLANNER IN TEAMS

Tasks by Planner and To Do will be the application for capturing actions in a Teams Channel. You won't be able to see your existing GTD lists inside of a Channel, but you will be able to create new Planner actions that can then be seen in that Channel or through the Tasks by Planner and To Do app.

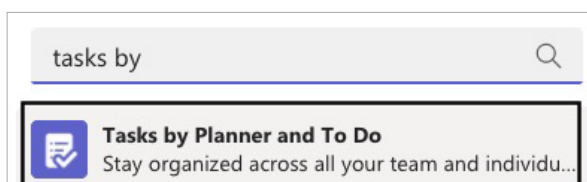
The benefit of Planner inside of Teams is that you can use it to track actions across collaborative projects. It's a powerful dashboard to bring visibility around who is working on what. The tasks assigned to you will then appear in your Assigned to me list in the Tasks by Planner and To Do app in Teams, in the Planner application, and Microsoft To Do. They will not appear in the Outlook for Windows desktop.

To see both your Outlook Tasks and Microsoft Planner Tasks across all Teams channels, add the Tasks by Planner and To Do app to your left navigation.

1. Click the ellipsis in the left navigation.

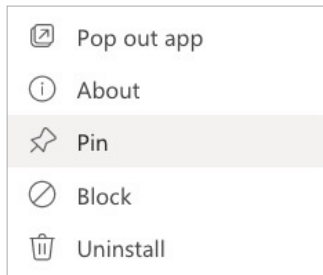


2. Find Tasks by Planner and To Do. Click Add.



³ These are the segments of our life and work that we need to maintain, to ensure stability and health of ourselves and our enterprises. E.g. health, finances, customer service, strategic planning, family, career.

3. Right-click on the app icon and choose Pin to keep it as a static app in your left navigation.



EMAILING TO TEAMS

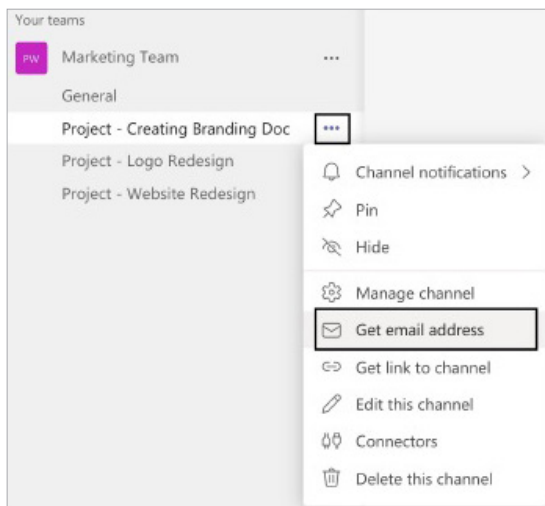
As you use Teams more for collaboration and project management, you'll find more opportunities to shift conversations and information out of email.

There are two ways to send emails to Teams:

- Email to a Channel
- Sharing to a Channel

Emailing to a Channel:

1. Go to the Channel you want to forward an email to.
2. Click the ellipsis to the right of the Channel name and choose Get email address. This copies the unique email address for this Channel.

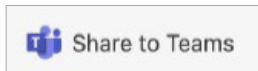


3. Send your email to the address you just copied. If you plan to email this Channel often, create the address as a contact.
4. Your email will be sent to the Posts tab. Unfortunately, it's not possible to email to any other tab within a Channel.

Sharing to a Channel:

As an alternative to emailing to the Channel, using the Share to Teams button in your Outlook for Windows or Mac ribbon. If enabled by your IT department, accomplishes the same result but even more efficiently. Share to Teams is not currently a feature in Outlook for Web.

1. Highlight or open an email you want to share to Teams.
2. Click the Share to Teams button in the ribbon. If you don't find it in your Outlook for Mac or Windows ribbon, look under the ellipsis to the right of the message when the message is in preview or open. If not there either, it's likely not enabled by IT for you.



3. Choose to send your email to a person, group (chat), or Channel by typing a name or choosing from recent items that appear.



Person – Sent through Chat

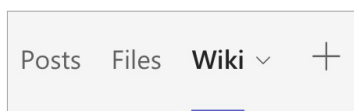
Group – Sent through Chat

Channel – Sent to Post feed for a specific Channel and a copy of the email is also captured under Files tab for that Channel

4. Add a message if you want to include additional information.
5. Click Share button to send to Teams.

USING WIKI IN TEAMS

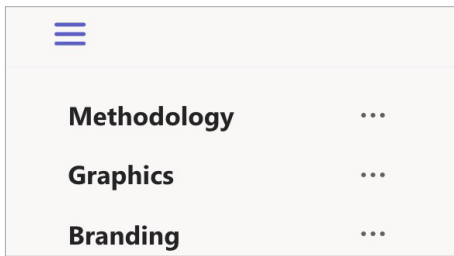
Wiki in Teams is a simple notes-style app that is included as a default tab in all new Channels. You can also add additional Wikis through the + symbol.



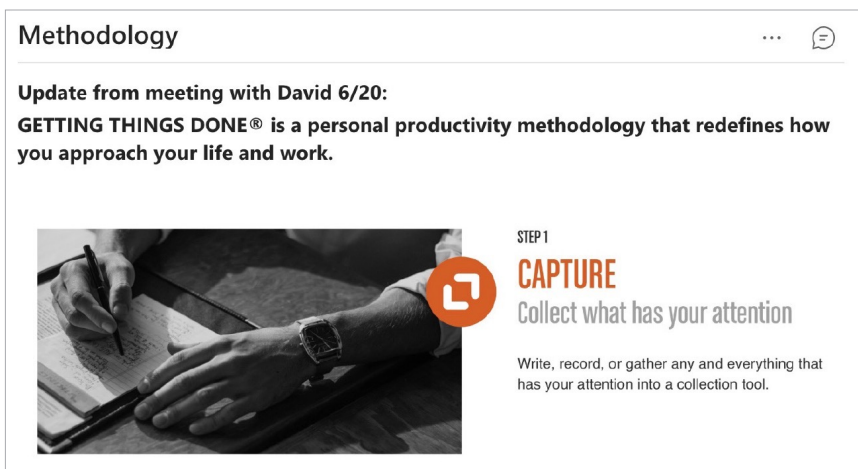
At first glance, Wiki seems like an underpowered app and many people want to jump to add more sophisticated apps such as OneNote or Word. Give Wiki a chance. There's an elegant simplicity to it for capturing and managing information.

Wikis are structured in a similar way to OneNote, with Pages and Sections.

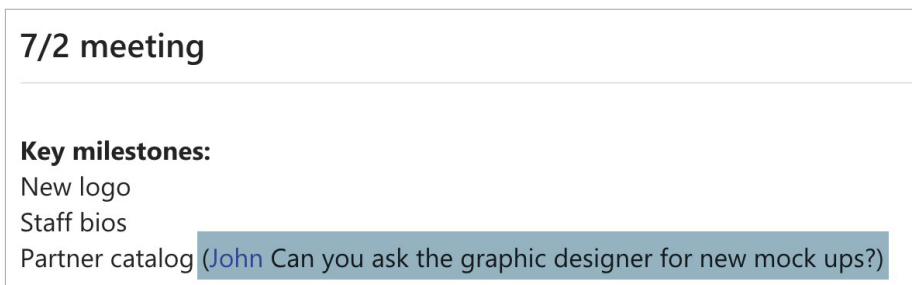
Example of Wiki Pages for project support:



Example of a Wiki Section for project support:



For your team workflow, a powerful feature of Wikis is being able to @mention your teammates to posted information in a Wiki by adding @[name]. They will be in their Activity Feed that they've been mentioned.

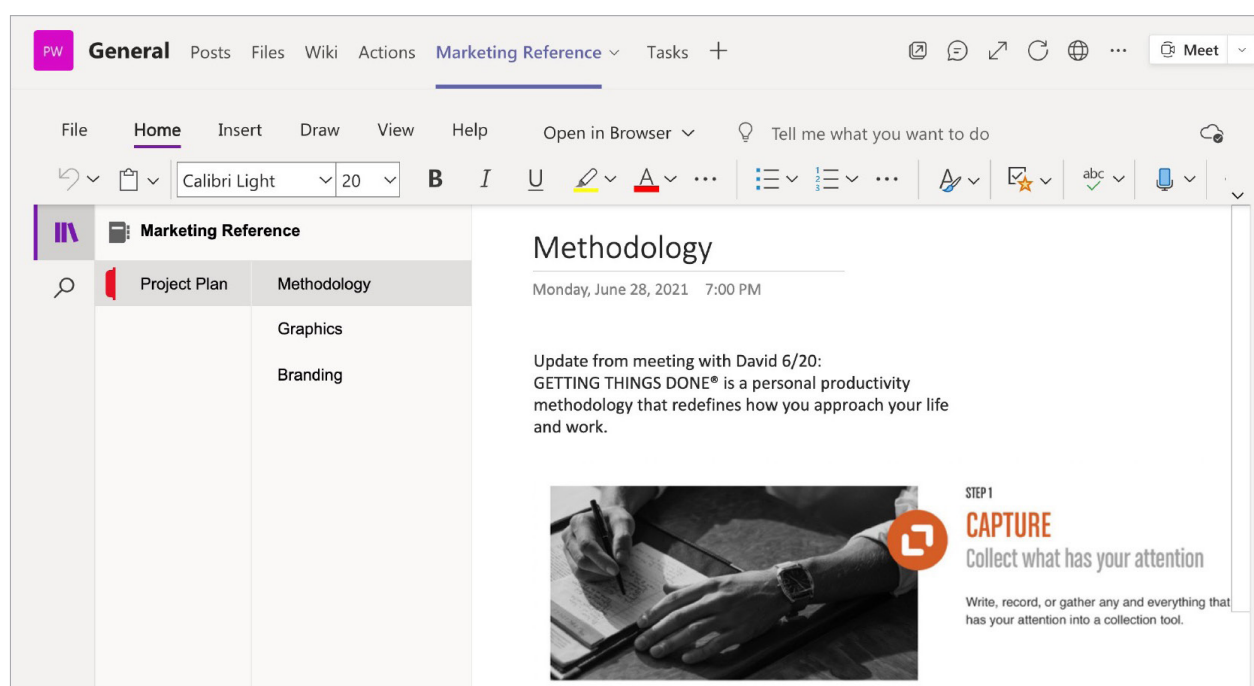


Note: You can only @mention members of the team you are posting to, for security. If you try to @mention someone who is not part of that team, they will not appear as an option in the name picker menu. After they've been @mentioned, the @ symbol disappears, so in the example above, @john became simply John.

USING ONENOTE IN TEAMS

If you're looking for a more robust app than Wiki to capture project notes and plans, consider adding Microsoft OneNote as a Channel Tab. Wiki is still a great option, but some people find the formatting capabilities more limiting. Also, Wiki is only viewed through Teams, whereas OneNote can be viewed through Teams, the web, on mobile, or your desktop.

1. Choose a designated team and Channel to add OneNote.
2. Click + to add a new Tab for OneNote.
3. Search or select OneNote from Recent.
4. Create a new Notebook or select one of your existing Notebooks. If you're not sure, select Create New Notebook to start with a blank slate.
5. Name your Notebook and click Save.
6. Add Sections and Pages for your project notes and plans.



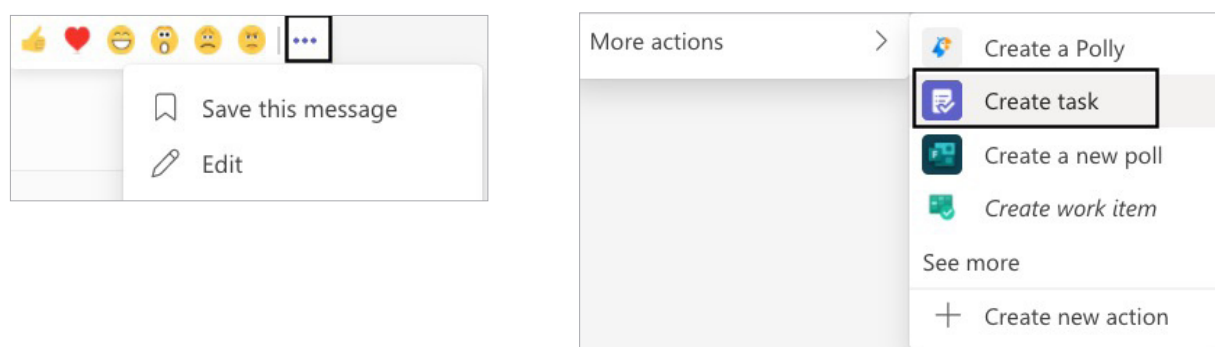
Anyone who is a member of the team will be able to edit the added OneNote Notebooks through Teams, in the browser, or in the OneNote desktop or mobile apps. Since it's all backed up to the Cloud, whichever method you choose, all your data will be synced in real time.

INTEGRATING YOUR PERSONAL WORKFLOW WITH YOUR TEAM WORKFLOW

If actions are being delegated to you in Teams through Posts or Chats, it's also important to have a clear system for integrating those actions into your personal workflow. Here are two options for how you could manage that.

Option One: Create a Task from a Post or Chat

Click on the ellipsis to the right of any Channel Post or Chat message, select More Actions, select Create Task.



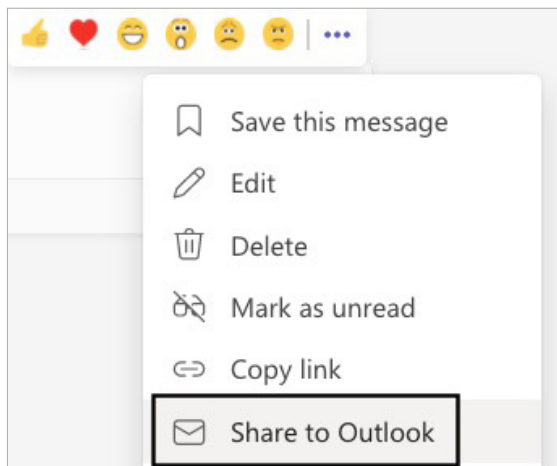
A task window appears with contents from your item in Teams.

1. Edit the subject line to describe your next action.
2. Select the appropriate list to organize the next action.
3. Add a due date if there is one.
4. Add any notes. You'll notice the note field also automatically includes a link to the original item in Teams, for your reference.

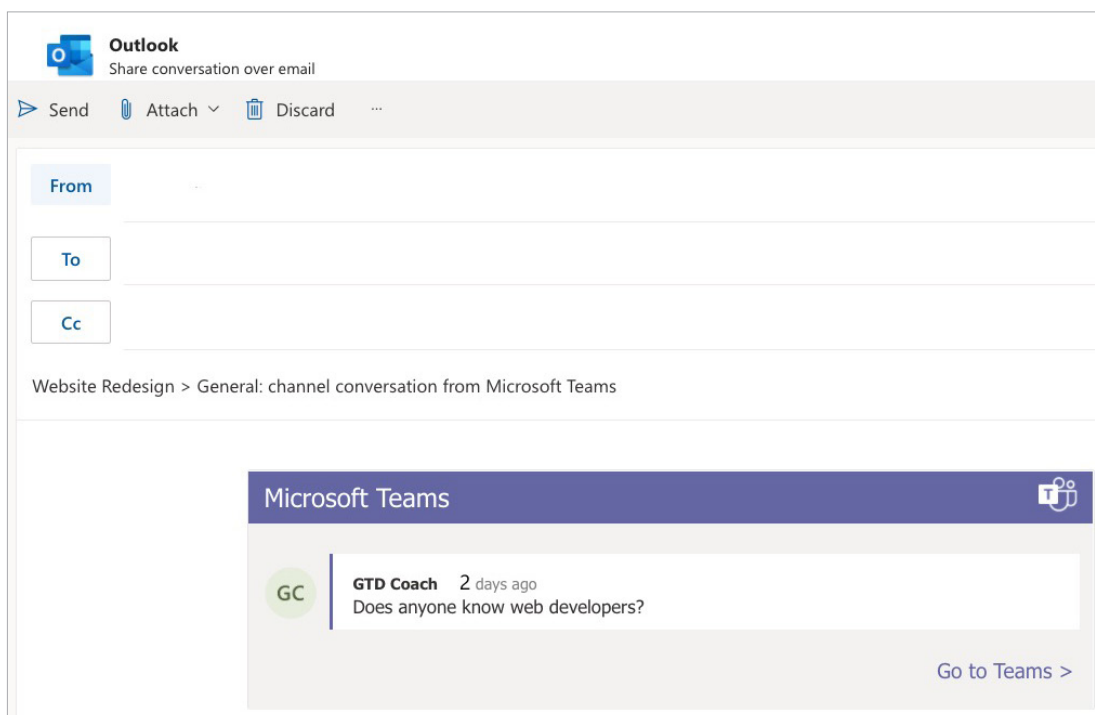
Click Add task to save the item to your Outlook Tasks and/or Microsoft To Do list.

Option Two: Share a Post or Chat to Outlook

To send an item to your Outlook email, instead of adding to your Outlook Task or To Do list, choose Share to Outlook. This can be useful if you want to file the item in a related project or topic folder or send it to your email inbox as a new item to clarify and organize later. Under the same ellipsis to the right of any Channel Post or Chat, choose Share to Outlook.



An email window appears with contents from your item in Teams.



Click Send to email the item to your Outlook inbox.

RECOMMENDED GOVERNANCE AND GUIDELINES FOR USING TEAMS

One of the challenges Teams users has been a lack of clear guidelines about how the Teams application is used. In many apps, how you choose to use it is up to you and your personal preference (like Outlook Tasks). Teams, however, is a team sport. As your use of Teams grows, it will be important to get clear on some guidelines and governance for how to use it productively. Here are some talking points to bring up with your team:

1. When are we posting to a team versus sending an email?
2. When do we send a chat versus send an email or post to a team?
3. Are we using Microsoft Planner to assign tasks or @mention? And is everyone clear how they will get notified when they are assigned a task?
4. How will new teams get created to make sure we don't have duplicates?
5. Who can create new teams and Channels?
6. What will be the naming convention for creating new teams?
7. Where will files be managed? In Teams Files tabs, SharePoint, or other location?
8. How should files be shared? Link to the file or send original file?
9. When should teams be archived, if at all?
10. What will be our quality check system to see if how we're working is working?

CONCLUSION

FINAL THOUGHTS AND NEXT STEPS

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

We hope this instruction guide has been useful. It is intended as a supplement to our core education of workflow mastery developed over many years—not a substitute. The most successful implementation of this guide builds on the understanding of the GTD best practices presented in our many learning tools, including the *Getting Things Done* book, the courses and individual coaching offered by our global partners, and our online learning center GTD Connect®.

Please visit our website to take advantage of the many support tools and training available to assist you in getting your GTD system up and running.

FOR MORE INFORMATION ABOUT GTD, PLEASE VISIT:

gettingthingsdone.com

gtdconnect.com